The CareLeaders

Programme brochure

The CareLeaders Academy

A leadership programme for care experienced young people aged 13 to 18, commissioned by councils and virtual schools.

Young people join as participants and leave as leaders.



Contents

03 Why we created it

04 What it is

05 Who it is for

06 How it works

07 The six modules

08 The workbooks

09 The young person's journey

10 Safe by design

11 What changes, and what you keep

12 Case study: Buckinghamshire

13 In their words

14 Your facilitator

15 Getting young people through the door

16 What comes next

17 Getting started

The CareLeaders Academy

Why we created it

Most councils want young people's voices in their services. Fewer give young people the skills and the platform to lead.

Young people with care experience know better than anyone what works in care. Councils want to hear it. But without training, a plan to reach young people and real roles to step into, participation stays a consultation, not leadership.

The Academy does both. It upskills young people in the areas your council needs them, plans recruitment properly, and moves them into real roles as equals.

That's why we created The Care Leaders Academy.

The CareLeaders Academy

The gap

01 Asked, not trained

Care experienced young people are asked to take part without training in speaking, co-design or influencing.

02 Hard to reach

Getting young people through the door is the hardest part, and many participation efforts stall there.

03 No real roles

Too few live roles where young people's experience changes a decision.



What it is

A 12-week leadership programme. Care experienced young people build the skills and confidence to take part in service delivery, service improvement and co-design. Turning care experience into leadership.

A skills audit
What your council needs, and what young people want to learn

A programme built for you
A training plan and the roles young people will take on

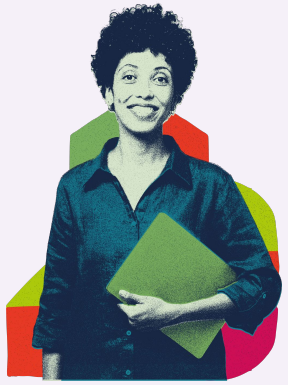
A recruitment campaign
A brochure, flyer, PA emails and WhatsApp graphics

Training
Two days, face to face, all six modules

Live roles
Service delivery, improvement and co-design in your council

Yours to keep
Session plans and materials, and train the trainer on request

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Who this programme is for

For	Care experienced young people aged 13 to 18
Group size	Up to 20 young people per facilitator
Who decides	You decide with us who the programme is for
Commissioned by	Councils and virtual schools

What it sets out to do

Young people with care experience become care leaders.

Three objectives, for every young person on the programme.

Skills

Leadership skills with evidence behind them

- Speaking to a room, from a short introduction to a keynote.
- Co-design and service improvement, working with staff as equals.
- Planning and co-delivering training for staff.

Confidence

Using their experience, on their own terms and safely

- Deciding what to share, and what to keep private.
- Looking after themselves after speaking.
- Holding their own in a room of senior professionals.

Opportunity

Live roles that shape real decisions

- Service delivery, improvement and co-design in your council.
- Training staff, and sitting on panels as equals.
- A pathway into The Care Leaders Fellowship as they get older.

What young people keep

- A workbook for every module
- Real examples to talk about at interview
- Skills in speaking, co-design, training and influencing
- A bridge into education, training or work after 16
- A place in how their council works

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How it works

Five stages, 12 weeks.

Every council needs young people for different things, so we don't sell an off-the-shelf course. We start with an audit and build your programme from it.



1

Weeks 1 to 3

Skills audit

What your council needs young people's help with, and what young people want to learn.

→

2

Week 4

Programme build

A training plan for your cohort, and the roles young people will take on, agreed with you.

→

3

Weeks 5 to 10

Recruit

A six-week digital campaign to reach young people in your area.

→

4

Week 11

Training

Two days, face to face. All six modules, with time to rehearse.

→

5

Week 12

Take part

Young people step into live roles in your council.

Story. Lived and professional experience open every session

Theory. The evidence underneath gives it rigour

Action. Tools young people use straight away

Six modules over two days.

Two days, face to face. All six modules, shaped by your skills audit, with time to rehearse and co-facilitate. Every module comes with a workbook young people keep.



1 Sharing your story safely

On your own terms

Use their own experience to make a point, while deciding what to share and what to keep private.

- Choosing what to share
- Linking a story to a message
- Looking after themselves

2 Public speaking and keynotes

Speak to a room

Plan, write and deliver a talk, from a short introduction at a meeting to a keynote.

- Structuring a talk
- Speaking with confidence
- Handling questions

3 How your council really works

Know the system

Who makes decisions, how services are run and paid for, and where young people can have a say.

- Mapping who decides what
- Finding who to influence
- The corporate parent role

4 Co-design and service improvement

Change a service

Work alongside staff as equals to look at a service, spot what could be better and design changes.

- Seeing a service from the user's side
- Generating and testing ideas
- Working with staff as equals

5 Training the workforce

Teach the professionals

Plan and co-deliver training for staff, such as social workers or foster carers.

- Planning a short session
- Running a group activity
- Co-facilitating with a trainer

6 Leading and influencing in meetings and panels

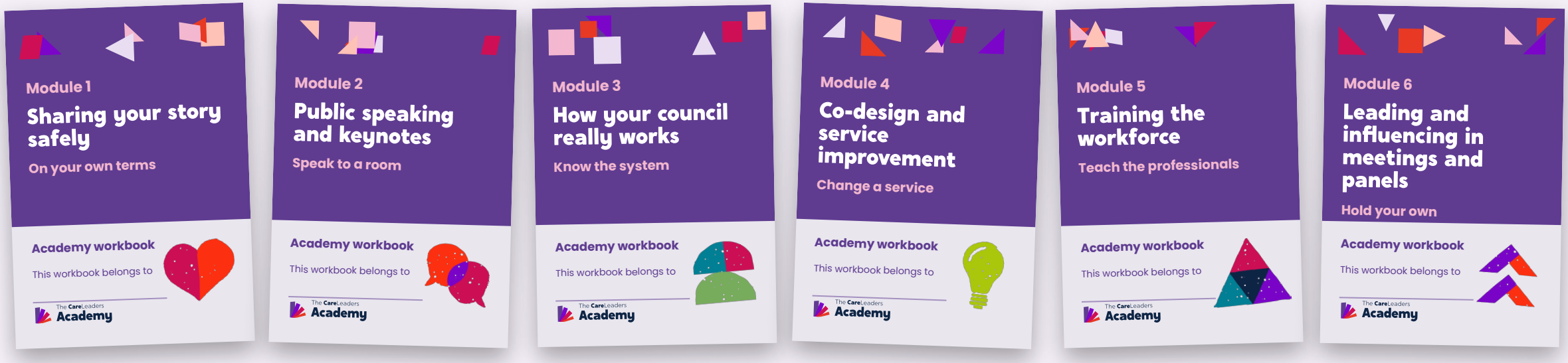
Hold your own

Prepare for a meeting or panel, get a point across and influence a decision.

- Preparing for a meeting
- Making a case clearly
- Following up so things happen

A workbook for every module.

Young people use their workbook in the training and keep it afterwards, so the learning stays with them when they step into a live role.



One for every module

Six workbooks, built around what your skills audit shows

Written for young people

Plain English, with space to plan, practise and reflect

Theirs to keep

Evidence of what they learned, for a CV, UCAS form or interview

At a glance

The Academy in numbers.

13 to 18	**Ages** Care experienced young people in your area
20	**Young people** Per facilitator, at most
6	**Modules** Shaped by the skills audit
2	**Days** Of face-to-face training
4	**Ways to reach** Brochure, flyer, PA emails, WhatsApp
12	**Weeks** From audit to taking part

The young person's journey

From first hearing about it to leading.

1 Hear about it

A PA, social worker or carer they trust sends them our email or a WhatsApp graphic about the Academy.

Trusted adults asking is what gets a young person there.

2 Sign up

A brochure written for young people explains what they are signing up to.

No surprises on the day.

3 Train

Two days with facilitators who bring lived and professional experience.

We contract the room together at the start.

4 Take part

A live role in the council: a keynote, a training input, a panel or a co-design project.

Their experience shapes a real decision.

5 What's next

Material for a CV or UCAS form, and real examples to talk about at interview.

A pathway into The Care Leaders Fellowship.

Sharing your story is always a choice. We teach young people how to decide what to share, and nobody has to share anything to take part.

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Safe by design

Young people share real experience in a room of professionals. We plan for that from the start.

Every facilitator brings lived and professional experience. Every session is built so young people stay in control of what they share.



The CareLeaders Academy

Enhanced DBS checks
For every facilitator

Your safeguarding framework
We work within it, from the first session

Trauma-informed facilitation
Throughout the programme

Sharing is a choice
We teach young people how to decide what to share

Consent and check-ins
With clear routes for any disclosure

We contract the room
With young people, at the start

What changes

Young people's experience shaping real decisions.

01 **For young people.** Skills in speaking, co-design, service improvement, training and influencing, and evidence of them for a CV or UCAS form.

02 **For your services.** Young people who can co-design, train staff and sit on panels as equals.

03 **For your council.** Young people's experience shaping real decisions, and a bridge into education, training or work after 16.

A pathway, not a one-off

As young people get older, the Academy leads on to The Care Leaders Fellowship, our 12-month leadership programme.



What you keep

Nothing we build stays ours.

- Your skills audit, and the programme built around it
- Session plans, slides and a workbook for all six modules
- The six-week recruitment campaign, with all its assets
- Train the trainer on request, so your team can run it again
- A trained group of young people, ready for live roles

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Case study

Buckinghamshire Council

Buckinghamshire Council

December 2020 to 2022. Strategy, restructure, brand, training and launch.

1 participation service, merged from two teams

19 participation champions from 11 service areas

6 all-staff training sessions, with 50 to 121 people at each

3 brands co-designed with young people

A participation service young people named, branded and shaped.

Youth voice in Buckinghamshire was spread across two teams, with no shared strategy and no single place for young people to go. Every training session and workshop was led by people with lived experience of care. Young people didn't just advise on the brand; they designed it. The Academy builds on this work.

Strategy

Listen, Act, Respond and Repeat: the 2021 to 2024 Participation Strategy.

Brand

Young people designed three brands: Youth Voice Bucks, We Do Care and Shout Out For SEND.

People

A Champions Programme, with 19 champions from 11 service areas, and six all-staff training sessions.

Launch

A launch conference on 6 September 2021, then monthly training that reached over 100 professionals.

What runs now

Youth Voice Bucks is still the council's participation service. Its annual Bucks Youth Summit now brings around 160 young people and more than 100 professionals together to shape services.

Young people leading elsewhere

Regional Care Cooperative, South East

18 Youth Ambassadors recruited to a regional Shadow Board, in a collective young people named and branded.

Liverpool Virtual School

Five young people designed and ran their own workshop at the Virtual School's 2025 conference.

In their words

They have a unique ability to relate to and engage the young people our strategy is targeted at.

Stuart Parker, Buckinghamshire Youth Voice
On our participation work, 2023



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Luke Rodgers BEM
Founder and CEO, The Care Leaders

Your facilitator

From care leaver to care leader.

Luke went into care at 10. At 15 he was living in a bed and breakfast, and at 18 in a caravan. He gave his first keynote at 19 and has spent his career since inside children's services, as a consultant, trainer, board member and national engagement lead.

He has spent his career making sure young people are heard in the services that shape their lives, and trained to do the work themselves. In Buckinghamshire he helped bring two youth voice teams together into one service, Youth Voice Bucks, with 19 participation champions and three brands designed by young people.

He built a participation network for care experienced young people across the South East, founded the Care Leavers National Movement, and worked with Liverpool Virtual School on a conference where young people designed and ran their own workshop.

He founded The Care Leaders in 2017, and it has since worked with 36 local authorities and national bodies, including the Department for Education and the NHS. Young people who finish the Academy can go on to The Care Leaders Fellowship as adults, which he also leads.

- **Gold, Dual Perspective Leadership Award**
  iESE Public Sector Transformation Awards 2026

- **British Empire Medal**
  2018, for commitment to children and families

- **Knowledge Equity Fellow**
  Saïd Business School, University of Oxford, 2020 to 2021

- **Social Entrepreneur Fellow**
  School for Social Entrepreneurs, 2015 to 2017

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Getting young people through the door

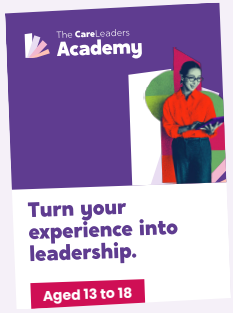
We plan for the hardest part.

Getting care experienced young people to engage with an opportunity like this is the hardest part. So we make everything you need to advertise the programme to young people, and hand it to your council for a six-week campaign. The aim is simple: young people turn up.

How we help young people sign up and attend

- A trusted adult asking is what gets a young person there, so PAs send the emails and graphics themselves.
- We make everything, ready to send, on a six-week schedule we set with you.
- Young people's data stays inside your council.
- We check in on sign-ups as the campaign runs.
- Information is written for young people, so they know what they are signing up to.

What we make to advertise the programme



1 A brochure

Written for young people, so they know what they are signing up to



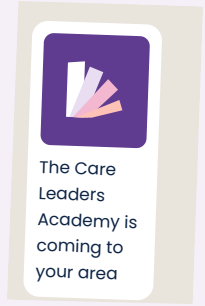
2 A flyer

For carers, schools and youth groups to hand out



3 Emails for PAs

Ready for personal advisers to send to young people



4 Text and WhatsApp graphics

With the programme details, ready to forward

What comes next

Looking for something for 18+?

Leadership doesn't stop at 18. As young people from the Academy grow into adults, they can progress to The Care Leaders Fellowship, our national programme for anyone over 18 who is care experienced or works with care experienced people.

Fellows bring an idea, project or business that solves a problem for care experienced people. It doesn't need to be polished.

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Aged 13 to 18

Leadership skills and live roles in their council

→

The Care Leaders Fellowship

Aged 18 and over

A national 12-month programme to turn an idea into a project or business that lasts

The CareLeaders Academy

The CareLeaders Fellowship

We invest in ideas that solve problems for care experienced people.

The Five S framework

- **S1** **Storytelling** · Why it matters
- **S2** **Skills** · What you need to lead it
- **S3** **Strategies** · How it will work
- **S4** **Scaling or sustaining** · Grow it or secure it
- **S5** **Succession planning** · Make it last

12 months
A year-long programme, with a new cohort each year

Two retreats
Four days each, away from the day job

Every month
A two-hour online session

Applications
Get in touch to find out when they open

Run by The Care Leaders Fellowship CIC. Get in touch to find out when we are opening applications.

The CareLeaders

The CareLeaders Academy

Getting started

Four steps to your first Academy.

1 Get in touch

Email us, or scan the QR code and fill in our short form about your young people.

2 Have an initial call

We reply within 3 working days to book a 30-minute call about your young people and what you need.

3 We provide a quote

A proposal and a clear price within five working days.

4 We start

Raise a purchase order and we can start within two weeks.

hello@thecareleaders.com · 0800 233 5597

Scan to tell us about your young people

A five-minute form that gives us what we need for our first call.

What we need from you

- A named lead who agrees the roles young people will take on
- Social workers, personal advisers and carers who talk to young people about the Academy
- Your council's safeguarding framework, which we work within
- Live opportunities for young people to step into after training

Commissioned by councils and virtual schools. Contact us for a price.

iese Awards GOLD Winner 2026 The Public Sector Transformation Awards

Children & Young People Now Awards 2023 Winner

Gold, Dual Perspective Leadership Award, iESE Public Sector Transformation Awards 2026.
Children & Young People Now Workforce Development Award 2023.

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